

HOLY WAR: Members at a protest in Delhi



THE ROGUE ARMY

The Bajrang Dal's brutal attack on Christians across several states displays the use of terror tactics to spread their message of hardcore Hindutva

■ By Farzand Ahmed

This week, the 1.3-million-strong Bajrang Dal, stormtroopers of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP), will celebrate their 25th anniversary. In a sense, the celebrations had already begun in typical fashion last month, except, instead of candles and cake, it was torching of churches and terrorising Christians across Orissa, Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh—events that are more fitting to its calling and character. The current anti-Christian crusade, often violent, always intimidating and brazen in the face of a lacklustre response from the states concerned, evoked a sharp reaction from the UPA Government. The Centre warned the NDA-BJP ruled states of Orissa, Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh that emergency powers under Article 355 of the Constitution would be invoked if they failed to put a break on the outfit's current anti-Church campaign. The official statement read: "The Government is very carefully and actively watching activities of Bajrang Dal and we will

take appropriate action at appropriate time."

Fuelled by the "success" of their destructive crusade which has led to 4,000 homes belonging to Christians being razed and more than 50,000 forced to flee, the Bajrang Dal leaders have literally smelled blood and are in no mood to relent. "If the Centre dared ban the organisation, it will be forced to lick the dust," said Vinay Katiyar, firebrand BJP leader and founder of the Bajrang Dal. For the Centre, already under pressure from Islamic terror groups, it's a tricky call. Article 355 aims at protecting states from external aggression and internal disturbances but it gives the Government powers to impose President's rule if internal disturbances pose a serious threat to security. That point may have already come. The spate of attacks on Christians in Orissa and Karnataka have continued unabated since August 23 and, last week saw a church being attacked in Tamil Nadu—the fourth state to witness the organisation's mindless carnage.

The Bajrang Dal call themselves "warriors of Hindutva revolution" and the fact that the